Captain's Guide

companion page for the Meal Train Sign-Up Sheet

You're about to do the kind thing: pull meals together for someone in a new-baby blur, on the far side of surgery, or in the middle of a genuinely hard season. This sheet keeps that kindness organized so it lands as food on a porch instead of a group-chat marathon.

Start like a captain, not a caterer

— Pick the range first — usually two or three weeks, not "as long as it takes," which exhausts everyone including you.

— Anchor a rhythm: three dinners a week beats seven nights of pressure for everyone. Gaps are allowed. Gaps are dinner reservations, not failures.

— Sign your own name on a real date on this sheet. If the captain's calendar isn't on it, the sheet can stall.

Working the sign-ups

— Hand this sheet to people face to face when you can — a pen offered at church, work, or book club fills rows faster than a forwarded message.

— Tuesdays and Wednesdays are where meals go to die. Suggest them cheerfully; they're nobody's first pick and everybody's real need.

— Watch the cluster problem: everyone says "Sunday," then Monday has tumbleweeds. When you see it forming, fill gaps yourself.

— Store-bought counts. Takeout gift cards count. Paper plates count. Say that out loud at the start, and you'll lose fewer volunteers to "I don't really cook."

Gentle gotchas

— Confirm each volunteer the day before their date. One text, and the family eats on schedule.

— If someone overcommits, it's kinder to un-sign them than to hope. You're protecting their friendship with the family, too.

Nobody remembers the perfect menu. They remember who showed up, and the person who showed up for everyone — that's you. Keep it light, keep it moving, and pass the pen when someone offers.